

FROM HAG TO HERO

witches in film and television

Depictions of the witch in popular culture have changed since the early 20th century. From early incarnations of a warty old woman, the image has been modernized to represent female empowerment—sometimes for good or for mischievous entertainment and at other times frightening, unsettling, or plain evil.

Changing face of witches

The film *Häxan* presented the first screen depiction in 1922, with a macabre evocation of medieval witches, while Disney's 1937 *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs* depicted a cartoon version. So began a trend for witches as evil persecutors of the innocent that persisted in later films such as *Sleeping Beauty* and *The Little Mermaid*, adapted from fairy tales. Yet the classic green-faced witch who features in *The Wizard of Oz* (1939) is countered by a benign witch, Glinda, introducing the idea that powerful witches could be good as well as bad.

The second half of the 20th century heralded a new type of witch—a seemingly ordinary woman with extraordinary powers. In the 1964 US sitcom *Bewitched* a housewife gently undermined her husband with magic; and in 1971, *Bedknobs and Broomsticks* featured a trainee witch who stopped a Nazi invasion with her spells. While the tone was lighthearted, these witches represented powerful women undermining the patriarchy—one of the tenets of modern witchcraft.

◀ Wicked Witch

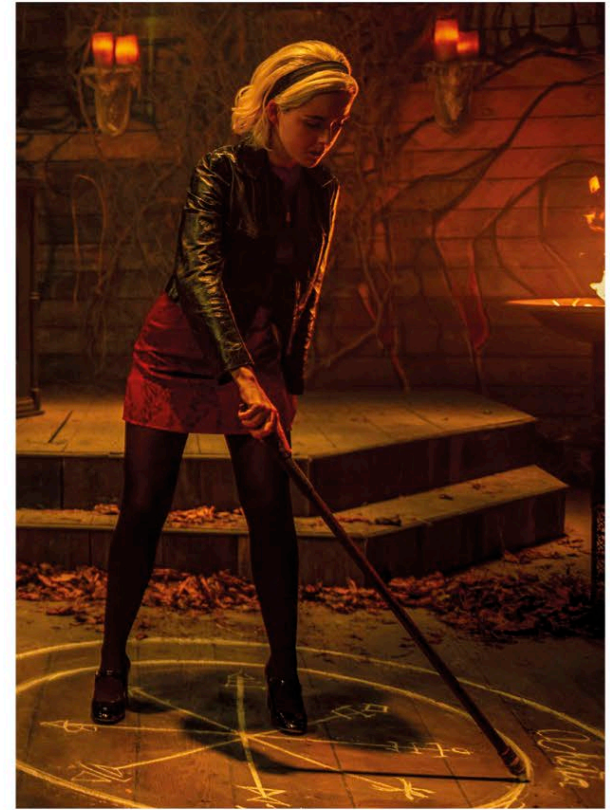
The 1939 film *The Wizard of Oz* included an iconic on-screen interpretation of a witch. The Wicked Witch of the West set a visual template for witches in popular culture that lasted for decades.

The message of female empowerment continued through the '80s and '90s: in *The Witches of Eastwick* three witches cast out a male oppressor; both *Practical Magic* and the TV series *Charmed* also celebrated the sisterhood. In the late '90s came the rise of the teen witch. *Sabrina the Teenage Witch* and *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* brought the feminist message to a younger audience, even (in a groundbreaking move) depicting an on-screen lesbian relationship.

The darker side

The role of the witch has been revised to take a darker turn in some cases since the late '90s. In the supernatural horror film *The Craft*, four outcast teenage schoolgirls are witches bent on revenge, and in *The Blair Witch Project*, which terrified audiences by purporting to be a shakily shot true story, a malign, unseen witch haunts the woods. More recently, *The Witch* (2015), set in 17th-century New England, presented an equally threatening landscape, one that harbored a powerful and ambiguous witch.

The Chilling Adventures of Sabrina, a series for younger viewers, recasts its '90s predecessor in a macabre light, while *American Horror Story* depicts witches as powerful figures, darkly sexual and ruthless, but not always evil. The witch continues to fulfill many on-screen roles—cautionary tale, symbol of resistance, feminist fantasy, malign force, and, above all, a female hero for modern times.



▲ The modern macabre

The dark coming of age story *The Chilling Adventures of Sabrina* mixes horror, witchcraft, and the occult, and taps into the current vogue for cinematic depictions of witches as powerful feminist figures.

“Who would have thought a good little girl like you could destroy my beautiful wickedness?”

THE WICKED WITCH OF THE WEST, *THE WIZARD OF OZ*, 1939